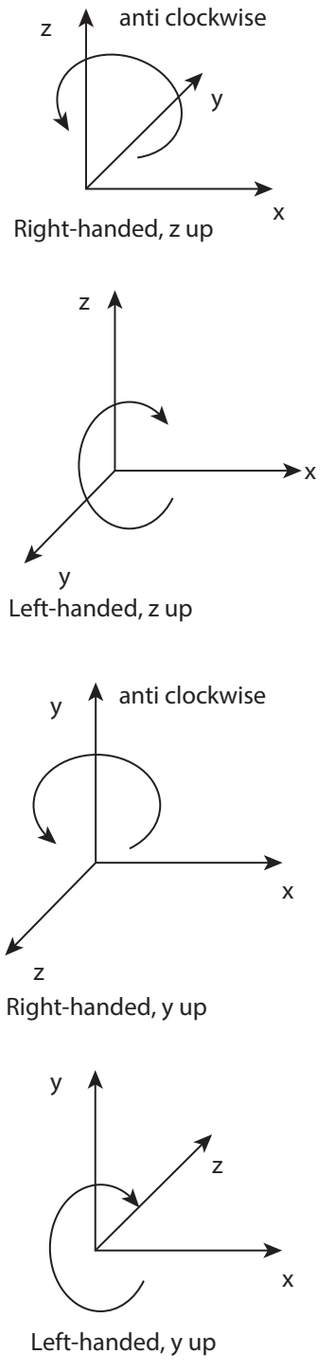


Figure 2.4 Right and left handed coordinate systems

Point mass

To explain the motion of an object which has finite mass, the concept of "point mass" is required and is very useful. Let the mass of any object be assumed to be concentrated at a point. Then this idealized mass is called "point mass". It has no internal structure like shape and size. Mathematically a point mass has finite mass with zero dimension. Even though in reality a point mass does not exist, it often simplifies our calculations. It is to be noted that the term "point mass" is a relative term. It has meaning only with respect to a reference frame and with respect to the kind of motion that we analyse.

Examples

- To analyse the motion of Earth with respect to Sun, Earth can be treated as a point mass. This is because the distance between the Sun and Earth is very large compared to the size of the Earth.
- If we throw an irregular object like a small stone in the air, to analyse its motion it is simpler to consider the stone as a point mass as it moves in space. The size of the stone is very much smaller than the distance through which it travels.

Types of motion

In our day-to-day life the following kinds of motion are observed:

a) Linear motion

An object is said to be in linear motion if it moves in a straight line.

Examples

- An athlete running on a straight track
- A particle falling vertically downwards to the Earth.

b) Circular motion

Circular motion is defined as a motion described by an object traversing a circular path.

Examples

- The whirling motion of a stone attached to a string

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